The Role of Ashe

Robert William D'Escourt Ashe (Figure 14), having taken over as sub-collector and joint magistrate of Tuticorin barely ten days before the Coral Mills strike, was in the thick of bringing the administrative machinery down upon the Swadeshi company. He may have feared that the stationing of the reserve police and his superior Wynch camping in Tuticorin was a verdict on his abilities. He certainly took the tough bargaining by a resolute VOC in the strike talks as a personal slight. The 'riots' of 13 March crowned his difficulties. When he marched into the Vandipettai to quell the restive crowd who counter-attacked from all sides, his heart must have been in his mouth. Personal danger apart, the strike and the massively attended near-daily political meetings had undermined his authority. Though he had the backing of Wynch, his immediate superior, he was not sure if his record at the highest level would be without blemish. All these must have weighed heavily on his mind, prompting Ashe to hit back with a vengeance.